FOUNDERS WITHOUT BORDERS

Cape Town · Stellenbosch
South Africa

GUIDE FOR UNIVERSITIES & STUDENTS

Founders Without Borders Global Internship

The Future Belongs to Those Who Build It

A 14-day immersion followed by a credit-bearing internship in South Africa's startup ecosystem, for U.S. college students and recent grads.

PREPARE

4 weeks

Remote matching and pre-departure workshops

IMMERSE

14 days

Build alongside founders in Cape Town

INTERN

4–6 weeks

Entrepreneurship or Impact Placement track

02 · SUMMARY

Take your learning beyond the classroom.

What is Founders Without Borders?

We connect U.S. college students and recent grads to global opportunities and curated immersion programs.

Our programs place students and recent grads inside an emerging entrepreneurial ecosystem, with the founders, investors and mentors who understand it from the inside.

What we solve

U.S. college students graduate with higher levels of student debt than any other graduates in the world, into a job market where 60% of entry-level opportunities have been made redundant by AI. Where will tomorrow's workforce find opportunity?

The world is full of opportunities. Accessing them is the challenge.

For ambitious founders, international growth isn't just about identifying new markets. It's about understanding the people, businesses and investment ecosystems that make those markets work.

Without the right connections, opportunities can remain out of reach.
Without local insight, it's difficult to know where to begin.
And without meaningful relationships, international expansion can feel like a distant ambition rather than a realistic next step.

Global Internship summary

Founders Without Borders works with universities, students and recent grads to open those doors, before and after graduation. Our Global Internships team works one-on-one with each student to find an internship based on their academic background, experience and interests, as well as host needs and availability, across industries including fintech, venture capital, clean tech, agri-tech, health care, financial services, consumer services, social enterprise, media, fashion and beauty.

Through an academic internship in Cape Town, South Africa, participants gain first-hand knowledge, connections and international work experience. Students on the program:

- Intern with founders, startups and impact organizations in Cape Town
- Earn academic credit for 120+ hours through a faculty-partnered or internship course
- Join a 14-day immersion with founder sessions, site visits and a Demo Day pitch
- Live with your cohort, with meals and ground transportation included

Three ways to take part

Faculty-led course + immersion
Winter, Spring or summer, integrated into a professor's course

Summer 2027 in-person immersion
Immersion + 4–6 week internship on site

Winter hybrid
14 days on site + remote internship

03 · COURSES

Built with faculty. Earned for credit.

Founders Without Borders partners with universities to integrate Cape Town into their courses or syllabus material, turning an emerging market into a living classroom. Students earn credit at their home university. Faculty get a ready-made field component, with real founders, real projects and the logistics handled. Every format is offered in spring or summer.

SPRING OR SUMMER · FACULTY-LED

Course + immersion

A professor's course and a live project with a Cape Town organization.

SPRING OR SUMMER

Internship for credit

120+ hours through the university's internship course or a faculty-supervised independent study.

Sample course: Building in Emerging Markets

Weeks	Focus
1–3	Foundations: emerging markets, market-creating innovation and the African startup ecosystem
4–7	Live project, remote: teams matched with a Cape Town startup or impact organization
Immersion	Cape Town immersion: founder sessions, site visits, investor meetings and Demo Day
9–12	Project delivery, with weekly check-ins with the host organization
13–14	Final presentations to hosts and faculty, reflection paper

Integrates into a professor's existing course or syllabus, such as global corporate performance, international strategy or entrepreneurship. Spring 2027 immersion: 6–14 March or 20–27 March, over spring break. Summer 2027: the same arc, compressed, with the immersion on site.

Students will be able to

- Analyze how businesses are built, funded and scaled in an emerging market
- Apply course frameworks to a live problem for a real organization
- Work across cultures with founders and investors
- Present a recommendation a host can act on

What faculty receive

- A syllabus template and seminar materials
- Vetted host organizations and project briefs
- Learning agreements, hours logs and host evaluations
- All on-the-ground logistics in Cape Town

Bring your course to Cape Town. **laurenne@founderswoborders.com**

04 · STRUCTURE

How it works

1 · PREPARE

4 weeks, remote

Mentor and host matching, learning agreement, two pre-departure workshops

2 · IMMERSE

14 days, Cape Town

Founder sessions, site visits, cultural immersion, Demo Day

3 · INTERN

4–6 weeks, on site

120+ hours in the chosen track, Mon–Thu, plus a Friday seminar

4 · RETURN

2 weeks, remote

Reflection paper, final evaluation, project showcase

Two internship tracks

TRACK A

Entrepreneurship Track

Accelerator-style: students build their own venture with a founder mentor, supported by workshops and course material.

- Weekly mentor sessions on the venture
- Venture-building workshops and course material
- Final pitch to an investor panel

TRACK B

Impact Placement Track

Students own a defined project at one impact organization, startup or social enterprise, and deliver work the host will use.

- One host, one defined project
- Weekly check-in with a host supervisor
- Host letter and final evaluation

Industries and themes

Fintech · Venture capital · Clean tech · Agri-tech · Health care · Financial services · Consumer services · Social enterprise · Media · Fashion · Beauty · Social entrepreneurship · Community-led innovation · Global leadership · Sustainability & ESG · Youth development · Impact investing · Policy & systems change · Education & equity

How we match students

We work one-on-one with each student to find a placement based on their academic background, experience and interests, and on what our hosts need. Faculty can shape placements around their course.

Earning credit and funding the internship

Only the student's home university can award academic credit, so Founders Without Borders gives each school everything it needs to approve the internship.

The benefits of credit-bearing internships

- **For students:** progress toward the degree, and eligibility for study abroad scholarships, most of which require a credit-bearing program
- **For faculty:** a structured, assessed field component that brings course material to life
- **For universities:** a global experience with clear learning outcomes and documentation

Three ways universities can grant credit

1

Internship-for-credit course

Students enroll in the school's standard internship course through the career center.

2

Integrated into a professor's course

A professor integrates the internship into their course or syllabus material.

3

Approved provider

The study abroad office lists Founders Without Borders as an approved program.

The Founders Without Borders credit package: seminar syllabus, signed learning agreement, weekly hours log, mid-point and final host evaluations, reflection paper rubric and a host letter of support.

Funding the internship

Because the internship is credit-bearing, it can open doors to study abroad scholarships and university funding. Students should speak with their study abroad and financial aid offices. Founders Without Borders is also building scholarship partnerships.

PROGRAM COST

14-day immersion: $2,500–$3,500 · Internship track: $4,500

Terms, eligibility and next steps

When internships happen

Term	Timing	Hrs / wk	Founders Without Borders
Winter	Mid Dec – Early Feb	20–40+	**Hybrid: 14 days on site + remote internship**
Spring	Early Feb – Mid May	10–20	**Faculty-led course + spring-break immersion, or internship for credit**
Summer	Mid May – Mid Aug	20–40+	**Faculty-led course + immersion, or in-person internship**

During the academic year, internships are part-time; outside of classes they can run up to 40 hours a week.

Who can apply

- U.S. college or university student with junior, senior or graduate standing
- Currently enrolled, or graduated within the last two years
- 2.5+ GPA and good academic standing
- 18 or older at the time of application
- Interest in entrepreneurship, global business or social impact

Recent graduates are welcome. Some scholarships require current undergraduate enrollment.

Students: next steps

1. Ask your study abroad office or career center about earning credit
2. Apply to Founders Without Borders and choose your track
3. Ask about scholarships and financial aid a full term ahead
4. Sign your learning agreement before you go

Universities: partner with Founders Without Borders

Credit partner

Approve credit case by case using the Founders Without Borders credit package.

Approved provider

List Founders Without Borders in your study abroad catalog so students' aid can travel with them.

Funding partner

Earmark funds for your students; Founders Without Borders reserves seats and reports outcomes.

Let's build it together.

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FOUNDERS WITHOUT BORDERS

PROOF OF CONCEPT · FOR UNIVERSITIES

The pilot worked. Now we're building it with you.

Pilot cohort · Cape Town, South Africa · December 30, 2025 – January 11, 2026

20+
organizations met across different industries

6
students from Syracuse and NYU participated

$28K
raised in year one from grants and revenue

3
terms for 2027: winter, spring and summer

WHAT WE RAN

A two-week immersion, sponsored by Syracuse University, the Harambeans and the Board of Curators. Students met 20+ founders, social enterprises and investors across agri-tech, fintech, food security, education, clean tech, fashion, hospitality and impact investing. Highlights included a leaders' day at Vergelegen Wine Estate co-hosted by iKapa.

WHO STUDENTS MET

Spero Optima · Oppenheimer · iKapa Impact · Peninsula School Feeding Association · The Smallest Ones · Global Innovation Initiative Group · OneThread · swiftVEE · Mosebe Enterprise · AnchorTech Academy · Newform · Seven Colours Eatery · Qwili · CleanClick · MyCommunity · AMAzink · Township & Village Experience · Justice Desk Africa · Harambeans · Impact Hub · SOZO Foundation · Curiocity

IN THE ROOM

> *"If you don't have visibility on the continent, how do you tell your story?"*
>
> **Jo Griffiths, co-founder, Global Innovation Initiative Group**

> *"Being part of the first Global Changemakers cohort helped me build the global network needed to expand my social impact work and drive broader, community-centered change."*
>
> **Walter Heisser, senior, NYU**







FOUNDATION IN PLACE

Cape Town operations partner on the ground

Legal counsel and partnerships in place before the first cohort

WHAT CAME OUT OF IT

- Students went on to continue building their ventures
- Ongoing mentorship with founders and leaders met in Cape Town

Artificial intelligence is accelerating everything. But the most valuable thing in business is still deeply human. That's why we believe the future belongs to businesses that combine:

Artificial Intelligence with Organic Excellence.

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